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Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1955-1957, 1964, 1974-1976

Coverage Date: 1955-1976

Place Coverage: Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): THE EXPRESSION OF EMOTION AT FUNERALS

Gusii men claim they need prompting and external stimulation to overcome their inhibitions enough for even conventional displays of grief. They find this in the women's wailing, the collective encouragement of the group (of men) that stands together to intone, and (in 1974–1976) in the blaring transistor radios and record players. The loud rock music constitutes a din they experience as equivalent to the war cries of the cattle drive and as putting them in the mournful mood appropriate to a funeral. In reporting this, they merge the sadness concerning the loss of the deceased with the vengeful anger of the cattle drive—a merger which apparently reflects both personal experience and social expectation.

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By the time of the burial and public gathering, the kinswomen closest to the deceased are often so exhausted that their public display of grief is somewhat subdued, and other women—recent arrivals—are more conspicuous mourners. The outpouring on the grave itself is often their last burst of energetic mourning, as they let others take over for them. The mourning that follows is varied not only by sex but by the individual mourner's relationship to the deceased. At two funerals of elderly women, the most conspicuous mourners, who were dancing on the grave long after others had stopped and weeping and wailing more grievously than any one else, were some young women *and men* who I discovered were the deceased's daughter's children. Having worked themselves into an almost frenzied grief, these young people showed by their prolonged and intense display how much their maternal grandmother had meant to them. This is particularly interesting because Gusii children are raised at their father's home and have only intermittent contact with their maternal grandmother who is known in Gusii lore as the primary joking partner for her grandson and the one who calls her daughter's children by their praise-names, that is, the names they are called only at their mother's home and which connote so much warmth and affection that informants report their use brings tears to their eyes. As in other patrilineal and patrilocal societies, so in Gusii the mother's kin, particularly her own mother, symbolize

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the unalloyed indulgence and emotional warmth that is superseded at (the father's) home by formal authority relations. The result seems to be that these grandchildren mourn with a greater intensity than others  54 at the funeral of an old woman, an intensity which, in the case of her male grandchildren, overcomes their masculine inhibitions about public weeping. Informants confirmed that observed behavior of maternal grandchildren at the two funerals was common and expected.

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